

How to Buy a New Car in Just 10 Steps?

For any individual or family, buying a new car is one of the most exciting life milestones, but it's also a significant financial decision. Every step is crucial to ensure you get the most for your money, from selecting the best model to comprehending how car loans work.

Here's a step-by-step guide that takes you through everything from setting your budget to driving your new car home, including insights on the car loan process in India to help you make informed decisions.

Step 1: Determine Your Budget & On-Road Price

Assessing Your Financial Situation

Assess your earnings, expenditures, and current debts first. Add in the price of maintenance, insurance, fuel, and EMIs. A rule-of-thumb to follow is that total car-related expenses shouldn't exceed 20–25% of your monthly income. To estimate EMIs and repayment schedules, use online car loan calculators.

Understanding On-Road Price vs. Ex-Showroom Price

Many first-time car buyers often make the mistake of planning their budget based only on the ex-showroom price. This price is listed by the dealer for the car itself.

The actual on-road price is always higher than the ex-showroom price because it includes several mandatory and optional charges. These typically include:

Ex-showroom price

RTO registration fees

Road tax

Mandatory insurance

TCS (Tax Collected at Source)

Handling and logistic charges

This final figure, after adding all these, gives you the actual cost of the car that you'll pay.

Factoring in Running Costs

Beyond the purchase, remember the ongoing costs. This can include fuel, routine servicing, insurance renewals, and occasional repairs.

Step 2: Research Cars and Shortlist Your Favourites

Identifying Your Needs

Start by listing what matters most to you. This includes family size, daily commute distance, driving conditions (city vs. highway), and desired mileage. For example:

Small families or city commuters prefer hatchbacks or compact SUVs.

Frequent highway drivers may look for vehicles with larger engines, better mileage, and stability.

Those with long daily commutes can consider fuel-efficient or hybrid models.

Exploring Popular Models and Brands in the Indian Market

Explore trusted brands and models known for reliability, service network, and resale value. For example, Mahindra models like the XUV700, Scorpio-N, and Bolero Neo. Research popular models online, consider resale value, and read user reviews to gauge long-term satisfaction.

Comparing Features, Safety Ratings, and Specifications

Compare safety ratings (like Global NCAP), engine performance, fuel efficiency, and features such as ABS + EBD, hill-hold assist, airbags, infotainment, and connectivity.

Step 3: Get Your Financing Pre-Approved

Exploring Car Loan Options from NBFCs and Banks

Once you have a shortlist, the next step is understanding how car loans work, unless you want to pay upfront. A car loan allows you to pay for your vehicle in easy EMIs, spreading the cost over a few years.

Most car buyers in India finance a certain percentage of the vehicle cost through loans from NBFCs or banks. Both NBFCs and banks offer flexible loans with quick processing and minimal documentation, particularly suitable for rural and self-employed buyers.

Get a Pre-Approved Loan Letter Before Visiting the Dealership

Pre-approval clarifies your budget and strengthens your negotiating power, as you effectively become a “cash buyer.” It also speeds up the buying process.

Understanding Lease vs. Buy

Leasing is still relatively uncommon in India, and mostly corporate companies use it. However, buying remains popular since ownership gives long-term asset value and freedom from mileage or wear restrictions.

Step 4: Locate Dealers and Schedule Test Drives

How to Choose a Reputable Authorised Dealer

Select authorised dealers with good customer reviews and transparent pricing. Authorised dealers ensure genuine vehicles, proper documentation, and reliable after-sales support.

What to Look for During a Test Drive

When you test drive your shortlisted cars, pay attention to:

Engine responsiveness and NVH levels (noise, vibration, harshness)

Air-conditioning effectiveness is especially important in stop-and-go city traffic.

Seat comfort and visibility.

Ride quality on uneven roads.

Important Questions to Ask the Sales Advisor

Before finalising, ask about:

Waiting periods

Available variants and colour options

Warranty and service packages

After-sales service reputation

Step 5: Get Final Quotations from Multiple Dealers

Compare to Save Smart

Comparing offers helps spot inflated fees or insurance markups. To increase your bargaining power, get detailed quotes from at least two or three dealers that include ex-showroom pricing, RTO, insurance, accessories, and handling costs.

Step 6: Negotiate the Final Deal

Focus on Negotiating What's Possible

Once you've completed test drives, request a detailed, itemised quotation from at least two or three dealers. Ensure the quote lists:

Ex-showroom price

Registration charges

Insurance premium

Extended warranty and accessories

Politely Decline Unnecessary Add-ons

Dealers rarely have room to reduce the ex-showroom price since the manufacturer sets it.

However, you can negotiate discounts on:

Dealer-provided insurance (compare quotes from multiple online insurance aggregators for better value and coverage).

Extended warranty.

Accessories like floor mats or seat covers.

Step 7: Finalise Your Booking and Paperwork

Pay the Booking Amount

Once satisfied, pay the booking amount and get a receipt. Booking amounts generally range from ₹5,000 to ₹50,000, depending on the model. Always get a signed receipt that mentions the variant, colour, and the promised delivery timeline.

Submit Essential Documents

You'll need to provide:

PAN Card

Aadhaar Card

Address Proof (electricity bill, passport, rental agreement)

Income Proof (salary slips, bank statements, or ITR for self-employed individuals)

Most lenders today accept soft copies or digital uploads, making the document submission process quick and hassle-free.

Understand the Sales Agreement

Read all terms carefully, especially cancellation clauses, refund terms, and delivery timelines. Keep a copy of the booking form and dealer quotation for future reference.

Step 8: Arrange for Insurance

Compare Insurance Quotes

Compare insurance premium quotes online across insurers for better value and coverage. Your dealer may also offer car insurance in partnership with an insurer

Choose Between Third-Party and Comprehensive Coverage

Third-party insurance is legally mandatory. However, comprehensive insurance provides broader coverage against damage, theft, and natural disasters. You can further enhance it with add-ons like zero-depreciation or roadside assistance.

Activate Policy Before Registration

The car's insurance policy number is needed for registration, so ensure the coverage starts before your vehicle's registration date.

Step 9: Conduct a Pre-Delivery Inspection (PDI)

Why PDI Matters

Before the car is officially registered in your name, inspect it at the dealer's stockyard. This is crucial to confirm that you're getting the exact vehicle allotted to you.

What to Check

Use a PDI checklist to examine:

Exterior (scratches, dents, paint finish)

Interior (seat fabric, dashboard)

Odometer reading (should be under 100 km)

Lights, wipers, infotainment system, and AC

Check the VIN

The Vehicle Identification Number (VIN) reveals the manufacturing month and year. Verify it to ensure you're getting a recent batch of cars.

Green Signal for Registration

If everything looks fine, approve for registration. Otherwise, raise the concern immediately before the car is registered in your name.

Step 10: Take Delivery of Your New Car

Final Inspection

On delivery day, take one last look to ensure accessories are installed correctly, all fluids are topped up, and the car exterior is spotless.

Verify All Documents

Ensure you receive:

Final invoice and payment receipt.

Insurance copy and policy details.

Temporary or permanent registration certificate.

Extended warranty documents (if opted).

RTO registration papers or temporary registration.

Finalise the Payment

After the final settlement, you're ready to drive your brand-new car home.

Conclusion

Buying a new car in India can seem like a long journey, but it becomes a smooth, exciting experience with the proper preparation. From setting your budget to understanding how car loan works, each step plays a crucial role in ensuring you get the best deal, the right car, and the perfect financing option.

Visit BuyCars for India Finance to explore how car loans work, check your eligibility, and get started on your car ownership journey, confidently, and in just 10 steps. With quick approvals, flexible EMI plans, and tailored loan options designed for every need, you can bring home your dream car without hassle or hidden charges.

FAQs

Q1. What is the first thing to do when buying a new car?

The first thing is to understand your budget using the 20/4/10 rule—plan for at least 20% down payment, limit your loan to 4 years, and ensure monthly car expenses don't exceed 10% of your income.

Q2. How can I get the best deal on a new car?

Compare loan offers from multiple lenders, leverage your good credit score for better rates, make a larger down payment to reduce the loan amount.

Q3. Is it better to lease or buy a new car?

In India, buying is typically better for long-term value and asset creation, which we can help you finance with a tailored car loan. Leasing can be a good option if you prefer lower monthly outgoings and like to change your car every few years.

Q4. What should I look for during a test drive?

During the test drive, pay close attention to the vehicle's comfort, handling in city traffic, and performance on open roads. Make sure to test all the essential features like the air conditioning, infotainment system, and safety functions to ensure they meet your expectations.

Q5. How much should I budget for car insurance when buying a new car?

You should budget around 3-5% of the car's ex-showroom price for your first year of comprehensive insurance. Most lenders require comprehensive insurance for financed vehicles, with some offering the option to pay premiums alongside monthly instalments for added convenience.

Buying a car in India is a basic necessity for some, a status symbol for the more indulgent, but a dream come true for most of us Indians. Whatever the reason may be, a car is an important part of Indian households. But buying a car is a major financial decision, which involves a great deal of savings and foresight. The concept of buying used cars started taking ground in recent years when people realised that used cars can be as good as new cars. However, many of us still refrain from

the idea as it involves tons of research and a substantial amount of risk. With the advent of online used car platforms, things have become easier for the common Indian.

Why Should You Buy A Used Car?

How reliable are used cars? The answer lies primarily with online used car dealers. Unlike offline used car dealers whose sole aim is to close a quick deal, online car dealers such as BuyCars for India make it a point to go the extra distance and check a car intensively before putting it up for sale. They also offer warranties and guarantees should the car run into any post-sale troubles. Combined with trust and reliability, Indian online used car platforms are fast becoming used car buyers' go-to source for buying used cars.

Buying Used Cars

The question that pops up in every used car buyer's head, and the answer to this question lies in many parts. Let us break them down for you.

- > Affordability
- > Lower Depreciation Rate
- > Lower Insurance Premiums
- > They Are Warranted
- > Great Quality Cars

Why Are Used Cars Affordable?

Used cars are affordable because they've been through depreciation and enough time on the roads to bring down their value considerably. While affordability is often seen synonymous with doubtful quality, any such doubts can be laid to rest by buying certified pre-owned cars from trusted vendors. Take BuyCars for India for example. BuyCars for India Assured cars undergo a very stringent 200-point evaluation, before being offered to prospective buyers.

Lower Depreciation Rate

This is the main reason why used cars cost less. Let us first explain what depreciation is.

Depreciation rate is the loss of value of assets one owns, in this case a car. The rate of depreciation depends on a number of factors but the primary cause that brings the value of a car down is its wear and tear, or its mileage. The higher the mileage, the higher the depreciation rate. And for a new car this means an average 15-30% loss of value after just a year. Used cars, on the other hand, have already been through the high depreciation phase, which means there won't be a significant loss of value once you try to sell it.

Lower Insurance Premiums

The Insured Declared Value (IDV) of a car is inversely proportional to its age, which means a newer car will have a higher insurance premium compared to an older one. A new car is of higher perceived value, leading to higher insurance costs. But once it starts clocking miles its perceived value starts to come down, due to a myriad of factors, which is why the insurance premium also comes down.

They Are Warranted

Similar to their newer counterparts, used cars from certified dealers such as BuyCars for India come with limited warranties, which can give the customer a sense of security when buying a used car.

Great Quality Cars

Nowadays, there is nothing 'used' about a used car. This is because certified dealers take great care in making sure that used cars match the appearance, the durability and the mechanical standards of a new car, thus ensuring high customer satisfaction.

Certified Vs Non-Certified Used Cars

Buy Used Cars

These are the two mighty contenders grappling in the used car market space. Certified used cars are a recent phenomenon while non-certified players have been in the market for quite a time.

What is the difference between the two?

A non-certified seller can be anyone. It can be your neighbour trying to sell their used car, an offline car dealer, your friends, relatives, and so on. In short, non-certified sellers are private sellers who don't offer any certification for the vehicle they sell. No certification means there won't be any way you would be able to tell what the car has been through, whether it has had an accident, whether the meter has been tampered with, and if the service details mentioned are true or not. However, you might be able to get the car for the best price if you are directly buying from the seller, eliminating the middlemen, but this might not be the case with offline dealerships.

Certified used car dealers, on the other hand, are quite transparent. They only offer cars that pass their quality tests. A certified used car comes with all the relevant details a buyer looks for, right from the car's service history to the physical quality. On the flip side, these might cost more than non-certified cars, but you also get peace of mind with the warranty and guarantee that come along with them.

Buying A Used Car

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Made your decision? Let us tell you about the important steps you should keep in mind while buying a used car.

Selecting The Car

A very crucial aspect of buying a car, is car selection. It would be wise and pocket-friendly to buy a car that suits your lifestyle and needs. For example – a big SUV may not be the most apt choice for your daily commute if you are single. A compact sedan for a family of 6 that's fond of those long drives isn't the best choice, either.

Much like buying a new car, a thorough study of your needs should be done well in advance when buying a used car.

Explore All Buying Locations

After narrowing down on a car of your liking, it is the time to go and see the car for real. There are many options when it comes to buying used cars: it could be directly from the owner, used car dealers, and many others who provide the service of buying used cars. When you see a car that you like, don't hesitate to ask questions! Ask the seller the reasons for selling it and how it was used, inquire whether the vehicle was involved in an accident, and many more. The more questions you ask, the better are your chances of getting a good used car.

Here are places where you can hunt for a used car:

Directly From The Owner

The chances of getting a good bargain are pretty high in this zone, as you eliminate the brokers and speak directly to the owner. But it is a very cumbersome method and requires a lot of time and patience — and a trusted mechanic. You should not expect the owner to tell you everything about the car, and that's where the mechanic comes in handy. You can ask for the service book to ascertain the service history of the car. One more thing. Buying a car directly from the owner doesn't come with any service warranty.

Neighbourhood Pre-owned Dealer

Okay, so these used car dealers are quite a convenience. This option allows you to inspect a line of cars, all in one place. However, this doesn't mean that these cars are risk-free; there is a chance that the odometer might've been tampered with or the documents forged. It would be better to ask your mechanic to have a good look at the car, inside and outside. Second, these cars will cost more than what you would be paying if you go to the original seller directly. Make sure that the dealer is not the owner of the car; otherwise, it becomes a third-hand car, and this affects the market value of the car further.

OEM Brand Owned Used Cars

With so many used car dealers in the market, how do you know which one is most reliable? OEMs without a doubt. OEMS, or original equipment manufacturers, are car brands that have got their own used car dealership. These are the most reliable of the lot and you can rest assured that any car you buy from here will be the best. Moreover, they provide warranties and guarantees on the cars they sell, giving you peace of mind about the quality you get. Some of the well-known OEM used car dealers are – Maruti Suzuki True Value, Mahindra First Choice, Hyundai First Advantage, Premium Selection by BMW, Mercedes's Proven Exclusivity, and many more. The down part, however, is that these cars would be far costlier than other options in the market.

Online Classifieds

Sites like OLX and Quikr come under this category. They are time-saving and at the click of a button or a tap on the screen, you have a number of used car options in front of you. The portals do make life easy, but one cannot rely completely on the information displayed as this could be false as well. You will still have to go to the car check it out thoroughly and then come to a decision.

Online Used Car Retailers

Just like traditional e-commerce platforms, the online used cars retailers have an end-to-end managed system that requires negligible involvement of the customer. The advantage of these retailers is that like OEMs, they are completely reliable, transparent, and trustworthy. But unlike them, they don't cost as much. Cars you buy from these sources have reliable quality checks, affordable prices, warranties, and guarantees in place to keep you secure and peaceful if any problems arise. One such example is BuyCars for India. BuyCars for India Cars are not only reliable, but they also give you the guarantee of a full refund upon returning the car within 5 days if you somehow do not like it. In addition to this, their BuyBack feature guarantees a pre-fixed value of your car for up to 18 months, if you want to return or exchange the car. Online used car retailers have got everything under one roof, which means that even if you want to finance your car it can be done there and you won't have to look elsewhere for a loan. The downside of such places is that they are available only in select locations.

Testing The Car

Okay, so you've found a used car that you like and want to try it out. In all its actuality, a test drive is simply not just a test of the engine or the way a car drives. By taking a test drive your senses perceive what all you need and what all the car offers. Let us guide you through the finer points of taking a test drive.

A test drive should be long enough to tell you about the working condition of a vehicle, insist on driving for at least 5 kms through various types of roads to understand the car and your comfort.

The car should start instantly and there shouldn't be any strange noises apart from the hum of the engine.

Gears should shift smoothly and upon releasing the clutch the vehicle should move forward without jerks.

The steering should not vibrate. If it does then there is a major problem.

The brakes should also slow down proportionally to the force applied to them and this should happen in a straight line, the car shouldn't move sideways. If it does then the car has a major braking issue.

Lastly, check for oil leaks from the engine and the gearbox. Park the vehicle on clean ground and check if anything has leaked or not. If it has then there are issues that need to be looked into.

Do A Pre-Purchase Inspection Of The Car

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Alright, so now you know you like the car, it drives well and has passed your test drive expectations. The next step would be to do a short inspection before purchasing the car. Here's how you go ahead.

Check the relevant car documents such as the registration, insurance, pollution certificate, road tax clearance, and loan clearance.

Check the meter reading: a 5-year-old car with a run of 30,000 – 40,000 kms is the best vehicle to own.

Check the body: there shouldn't be rust anywhere. If there is, then it would be wise to call the deal off.

Start the engine and check the exhaust: there shouldn't be emission of blue or black smoke upon acceleration nor should there be oil spouts on the exhaust.

The tyres should be in top condition; if they aren't, then you've got scope for a bargain.

The wheels should be properly aligned: at speeds of 10-20 km on a vacant stretch of land, if you leave the steering wheel, the car should move in a straight line. If it goes sideways, the alignment is haywire.

The suspension should provide a noise-free and comfortable ride: Give an eye to the shockers, suspension springs, and bushings, there should be no leaks.

Check the battery and signs of acidic wear and tear near it. If the battery is close to expiry and is ill-maintained, you can bargain more.

Check whether the AC is working properly or not. Cooling should be gradual and upon an increase in levels, the cooling should also increase. Drive the car up on the slope to check the efficiency of the cooling system.

Check all the lights, dippers, hazards, indicators, brake lights, headlamps, and reverse lights. They all should be in top working condition. Electrical components like OVRMs, electric rearview mirrors, and the music system should function properly.

Do A Thorough Document Check

6. Check all important Documents

Documents are what make the car yours, make sure that you've laid hands on all the relevant documents listed below before you sign the deal.

Registration Certificate: This document proves that you are buying a car from a registered buyer and it is not a fake or a bogus purchase. That being said, you should always inquire about the veracity of the RC. The engine and chassis no. on the RC should match with those on the vehicle.

Insurance: The insurance can tell a lot about the vehicle and you can check it for past accident claims. This is a very important document for transferring ownership.

Pollution Certificate: The PUC or pollution under control certificate is required for ascertaining the fitness of a car and is required in ownership transfer.

Road Tax: Although the road tax is cleared during the time of purchase, if in any case it hasn't been cleared on the used car, you can bargain for the price.

No Objection Certificate: Issued by the finance company, this certificate states that all payments towards the loan have been cleared and the financier has no claim on the car.

Explore All Payment Options

How to Buy Pre Owned Cars in India

Test drive taken

Vehicle checked

Documents checked

So, you've checked everything and want to buy the car through a loan. Let us help you out.

With used cars you will have to consider the high interest rates that banks and NBFCs offer, but you can compare them and choose the one that suits your budget the most. Good upfront payment can ensure lower interest rates which would be easier for you in the long run. Buying from online dealerships has perks of its own as they provide assistance in availing loans for your used car purchase.

Transfer Of Ownership Documents

Congratulations! You've made the payment and are looking forward to getting the documents transferred in your name which would make you the whole and sole owner of the car. There are a few documents you would require to see it through.

The original registration certificate (RC) is required to be submitted to the RTO. If the car was purchased by a loan then a NOC along with form no. 35 would be required to be submitted to the RTO to confirm that the financier has no claim on the car. NOCs are usually valid 60 days from the date of issue.

Sale transfer form nos. 29 and 30 from the RTO need to be signed by both the buyer and seller in duplicates.

Vehicle chassis number imprint.

Notarised insurance papers, along with identity and address proof of both the seller and buyer. An affidavit may be required if the seller's address doesn't match with the proof of identity.

Notarised copy of your PAN card or form 60.

The BuyCars for India Advantage

Buying a used car can appear to be daunting at first glance but it is simplified with BuyCars for India. BuyCars for India is a full-stack pre-owned car retailing platform that removes the middleman while delivering more value and convenience to you.

BuyCars for India features more than 5,000 certified used cars to choose from, which have been evaluated on 200 points to ensure that you choose from the best used cars in your city.

Prospective buyers can search their desired car online, review the detailed report and images of the car, and get to know the car even before test driving it. Every BuyCars for India Assured car comes with Fixed Price Assurance, which ensures you receive the best price for the car without the need for negotiation.

The test drive experience has also been made convenient as BuyCars for India brings the test drive experience to your home. You can test drive your desired car in a familiar environment, getting a better idea of how the car will fit in your life. For further convenience, BuyCars for India also delivers your car right to your doorstep, for an unrivalled car buying experience.

Active in 18 cities and serving 200,000+ satisfied customers, BuyCars for India aims to make good quality cars affordable for everyone.

FAQ's About Buying a Used Car in India

Q. What's the best way to buy a second hand car?

Research carefully if you want to purchase a second-hand car. To guarantee you make a wise decision, search online marketplaces such as BuyCars for India for open pricing and detailed vehicle histories.

Q. How to buy a used car wisely?

First, figure out your needs and create a budget. Then, to make a more educated choice, examine models, check user experiences, and use a second hand car buying guide.

Q. What should I include in my used car checklist?

The most important items on your checklist should be car history, maintenance records, test drives, and a thorough inspection. These components will help guarantee the car's dependability and performance.

Q. Can I find affordable options at BuyCars for India?

Absolutely! BuyCars for India is one of the best places to buy used cars without compromising on the condition or dependability of the used car. They provide a selection of quality vehicles at reasonable rates with thorough inspections.

Q. What are some common mistakes to avoid when buying a used car?

Conduct a thorough inspection of the car and also remember to acquaint yourself with the vehicle's history. Ignoring potential problems or failing to replace crucial components that are not performing at their optimum levels could lead to higher expenses later.

Q. What is the process of buying a used car in India step by step?

Set a budget, shortlist models, inspect and test-drive the car, verify documents (RC, insurance, PUC, service records, loan NOC), and negotiate the price. Then pay, sign Forms 29 and 30, and complete the RC and insurance transfer.

Q. Which used car website offers same day delivery in India

BuyCars for India can deliver quickly, sometimes the same or next day, once payment and papers are done.

Q. Which are the top-ranked used car websites for buyers in Hyderabad?

BuyCars for India is a top pick in Hyderabad, with 200-point inspected cars, fixed prices and a warranty.

Q. Which are the most trusted used car platforms in Mumbai in 2026?

BuyCars for India is a trusted choice in Mumbai, with every car checked for flood and accident damage as part of its 200-point inspection.

Q. Which is the most trusted online platform for second-hand cars in India?

BuyCars for India is one of the most trusted platforms for second-hand cars in India. It offers 200-point inspected cars, fixed prices, a warranty, a 5-day money-back guarantee and hassle-free RC transfer.

Q. Which is the best website to buy a used car in India in 2026?

BuyCars for India is one of India's leading used car websites, with 200-point inspected cars, fixed prices and a warranty.

Q. Which second-hand car retailer in India offers doorstep test drives?

BuyCars for India offers free home test drives, so you can drive the car on your own roads before you book. Just pick a car online and choose a time slot.

Q. What is the best website for cheap used cars?

BuyCars for India is a great choice for cheap used cars, as even budget cars are 200-point inspected and sold at fixed prices.

Q. Which saves more in India, buying a used car or using a car subscription service?

Buying a used car usually saves more over 3 years or more, since subscriptions charge extra for flexibility. A subscription only makes sense if you need a car for a short time.

Q. Which makes more sense in India, a used car subscription or ownership?

Owning a used car makes more sense if you'll keep it for 3 years or more, as it costs less overall. A subscription only suits short stays or frequent moves.

Q. How can I schedule a used car viewing in Kolkata this weekend?

On BuyCars for India, you can pick a car online and book a test drive at a hub or at your home in Kolkata. Choose any weekend slot that suits you.

Top 10 Checks Before You Buy a Used Car This Festive Season

Looking to buy a used car in India? Here are 10 used car buying checks that you should definitely keep in mind

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Published On Oct 10, 2025 20:03 IST

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Used car Inspection guide

The used car market in India is thriving with high-quality cars across various segments and brands. There isn't a better time to go for a used car than ever.

What should you look for before taking your dream used car home? Here is our top 10 checklist that needs attention and consideration before finalising any model.

Ownership History

Ownership History

It is necessary to delve into the ownership, and remember, the fewer the better. Check if this is a first-hand or multiple-owner. Corporate-owned cars are generally better maintained. Often the past ownership reveals a lot about the car, such as usage pattern, average running, types of run- city or highway, smaller or large family, and also the maintenance practices, among other things.

Get accurate & latest updates from BuyCars!

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Odometer Reading

Odometer Reading

It is always better to have a car that has covered fewer kilometres. In India, an average car runs between 5000 -10,000 km annually. It is vital you verify the actual kilometres driven against the service record and overall vehicle conditions. There were a lot of concerns among buyers with authentic data, which led to a lack of trust; however, this has improved a lot.

Body and Paint

Car Body Paint

While most of the cars on display look better, they are supposed to attract buyers' attention. But it is not always what you see in front of you, but take a little effort in looking at what isn't obvious. Check for any damage by accident or rust on the body part or wheels, artificial painting that mismatches or changes in plastic parts, any panel gaps, and other exterior body damage.

Suspensions and Tires

car suspension

The condition of the tyres can be accessed by looking at them and checking right on the spot. Check if they're changed, the tread depth, and the uneven wear pattern. If they're changed, then better verify that against the actual bills. Remember, changing tires is a big expensive affair in the ownership lifecycle, and having good condition ones can help you run the car for a considerable time. Likewise, suspensions are equally important mechanical parts of the car; they're for comfort and convenience.

Vehicle Documentation

Buying a used car entails transferring ownership to you. Before you become the rightful owner of the car, check thoroughly all the vehicle documents, and all the papers must be in order. Verify the registration certification, followed by valid insurance, pollution certificate, vehicle service history and also any pending challans or hypothecations.

Engine Condition

Engine condition

Engine, as we all know, is the heart of the car, and an

enjoyable, peaceful, hassle-free ownership largely hinges on its condition. Besides, the engine determines the mileage of the car, which directly translates into running costs.

Interior and Electrical

The interior and electrical conditions are crucial for the car's usage. Always needs to test start/stop, air-conditioning, power windows, central locking, music system, all lights (headlight, indicators, cabin, trunk light), and wipers, etc. Also, look for any water seepage, dashboard warning lights, and seat condition, etc.

Test Drive

test drive

Make sure you get to drive for a substantial distance, in all types of driving conditions, city/highway, various speeds. Test drives allow you to get a hang of the car and understand its overall condition better on what is actually claimed on paper.

Insurance Claim History

Insurance is not just a mandatory legal requirement but a valid safety cover for your car. You must check and verify the insurance is in order, and never lapse, besides also know the history of claims. This will help you in multiple ways, like when you're renewing or making a claim. Insurance also helps you track the history of the car through claims; if there are multiple claims, this points towards accidents or major repairs.

Professional Inspection

inspection

It is also an option to make sure you don't miss anything about the car by availing a paid professional inspection service.

BuyCars, with its proven tools and huge collections of cars, make your used car-buying process simple, hassle-free and assures the best deal. We have in-depth and rigorous in-house inspection of the car, offering a warranty, even money-back assurance, full support with ownership transfer and paperwork

Needless to say, just like any other purchase, be prepared to walk away if something does not feel right. You would do this a few times before you hit the bullseye.

BHPian hothatchaway recently shared this with other enthusiasts.

I was on the lookout for a used car recently and did some reading up on the subject to come up with a guide. Sharing it.

Identify your need

First things first, identify your needs ie size, performance ease of ownership and your budget. If it is 3 lakhs then do not quote more than 2.75 if you are talking to a dealer. Try to keep a buffer for immediate after purchase repairs and do overs. For a Japanese hatch, this should not exceed 25-30k (including tires) if you have done your evaluation well. For sedans especially the temperamental European ones, this could be upto 10% of a car when bought new. The car may be available at a mouthwatering price but spares will not come at a discount. This is especially true for lux models.

Unless you are hung up on a particular make/model, do not be constrained by body type/make/model. You may want a sedan but if you are looking for a daily drive and are a family of three, a well kept hatch may serve you better. Try to ensure that the car has at least 4 years left before registration expires. That way, even if you trade it in after 2 years, you will still have decent resale. I did not consider diesel options. I was wary of costly repairs if my evaluation went wrong and was wary of an impending ban on diesel cars. Cars are more expensive down south than elsewhere so bear that in mind. The Japanese makes are more expensive than others for reliability and easy availability of spares. So if you know a good garage and are confident that you can pick up a ride in decent shape, you can consider the Fiats and Skodas which have bad resale. They are not bad cars and not everybody has a bad experience provided you know a good independent garage. The money you can save while buying one will help when you spruce up your ride. I almost picked up a used Linea Tjet at a mouthwatering price. The trims needed some work but the car was mechanically sound and drove like a dream. But fate willed otherwise.

Scouting for a deal

Unless you have a good source who can sniff out deals, you will sift through the usual suspects ie FB marketplace, OLX et al. Most of the options I found were just hustlers who posted cars at inflated prices on behalf of the actual seller and talking to these chaps are a waste of time for the most part. You will have to be patient. The belief is that its always better to buy from a direct seller but that is not always the case in my opinion. You can avoid unrealistic quotes which come from the emotional attachment of ones pride and joy by dealing with someone who earns his bread by plying this trade. Of course, it is on the buyer to do his due diligence. In my experience, the actual dealers (not the time pass hustlers) will inflate the intended sale price by 15% and will immediately reduce that the moment he senses that the buyer is genuine. They also have an urgency to move inventory.

So once you have zeroed in on options which seem to fit your need, you could do the following preliminary checks solely basis the information included in the classified ad -

Number of kms on the Odo (either extremes are red flags, I prefer a car which has done 75k in 5 years than just 15. Cars are meant to run and are often in ship shape when they do)

Number of owners (for every additional owner, you could try to haggle the price down by at least 10%)

Insurance validity - To me, a car with valid insurance indicates its roadworthiness. The copy of the current insurance reveals valuable clues like its IDV (great for a baseline to start negotiations for non popular models) and the NCB % which may indicate if any claims were made recently. Renewal requires reinspection and no RTO process can happen with a lapsed insurance. In fact, you cannot even do a legal test drive!

State of registration - Unless you are well hooked up with RTOs, avoid buying lets say a MH registered car in Hyd. The bargain offered is for a reason

Traffic Offences - If the ad reveals the registration number, check online if any challans are pending. In Telengana for eg, the challan also carries a photo of the car which will reveal the current exterior condition. Classified ads often carry images from the car's better days in the past.

The call

Once you have identified options worth pursuing, its time to make the first call. I tried getting as many details as possible at this stage as I did not want to run across town through mad traffic running after every red herring. This is what I tried verifying during the call.

Owner or poser? For individual listings, this was my opening question, the hustlers would usually get filtered out at this stage if you probe further.

Year and month of manufacture. Some sellers mention Dec 2010 cars as 2011 registered

Both keys available? Remember that in the case of theft, the insurer will ask for both keys. This may not be a deal breaker if the car is a decade old but remember to factor this in when its time to negotiate the final price.

Validate facts - Insurance validity if not mentioned, try and get a copy if its a dealer as the RC could be dated. When was the last service done and any major repairs. Ask if the vehicle is stationery and for how long. Always better to get a car which is running as thats what they are meant to do.

If you are after a particular model, like the VRS or the Tjet, research for common issues. So on the call you could check if the alternator or the mounts are still good.

Availability of original documents, especially the RC. Check if the car has a loan running as that would add a step to the final documentation

Reiterate the quoted price and see the reaction. Some sellers (especially dealers) may revise immediately by 10-15%

Schedule a visit asap if everything checks out. You have to move fast as good deals won't wait for anyone.

Visit and test drive

There are videos on YT and I found the series of videos on buying a used car by ChrisFix to be informative. This is what I followed

Visit during the day and in sunny weather - This is self explanatory and minor scratches and scuffs don't show up when the car is wet.

Walk around the car and get a good eyeful of it. A bad exterior may mean a badly kept car. though not always.

Check the windscreen, window and rear glass. If they do not bear the manufacturer logo on the corner then they have been replaced. You will have to find out why.

Check the condition of the tires and date of manufacture (1512 means 15th week of 2012) I preferred at least the front tires to be of identical make and manufacture. That indicates regular replacement of equipment. They are also clues to the genuine miles the car has done (a 6 year old car with 30K on the odo may not have needed new tires a couple of years back)

Check the bottom edges and under the beading of all 4 doors. That is the area where rusting usually turns up. If you find cars in coastal areas with some age and without rust, consider it to be a great starting point

This is the time to verify common issues which plague the particular make/model if you have done some homework. Like rusting issues for Jap cars or AC/electricals for certain others.

Pop the hood and check for any body lines that seem to be bent. That may indicate a shunt. Next, check the fluids and the belts for any wear. Then request for the car to be cranked while you stand next to the engine bay. Check for abnormal vibes and whining sounds. Check for leaks once the engine has idled enough to reach its operating temperature. If there is one, it will show up once the system is running and under pressure.

If the battery, tires and the suspension have at least another 2 years of life left, then that is some \$\$\$ saved at least immediately. Check the interiors, they offer clues on how the car has been driven and how much. Check the boot under the spare if your city has experienced flooding recently.

Start the test drive. Do have the dealer/owner with you when you do that. Ease the car out and see how she feels. I would turn the audio off to listen closely for anything unusual. Drive slowly over potholes and listen to the sounds the suspension makes. Turn the steering wheel from lock to lock at low speeds. Turn on the AC/CC after the engine has warmed up. Do all buttons incl the power windows work as intended? See if you can include stretches where the car can stretch her legs. Is the engine smooth or is there hesitation? Does she pull to any one side upon acceleration or braking?

Sealing the deal

If should have a good sense by this time if you have been able to put the car through her paces. While some would suggest that you get the service history vetted by the Auth. SS, not all cars which have seen more than just a few years have a complete record. That does not necessarily mean that they lacked care. Try to take a friend or family who are a little less passionate about the whole exercise can remain more objective. I trusted the wife with that. I have nothing much to add about the price negotiation as it is no different from any other big purchase you would make. Depending on your gut feel, you may hold back 15-20k if any work is promised before delivery or for ownership transfer documentation to be completed but don't do that as a point on your checklist. If you have a trusted mechanic, you could have him accompany you.

Needless to say, just like any other purchase, be prepared to walk away if something does not feel right. You would do this a few times before you hit the bullseye.

I am not including ownership transfer documentation as there are many threads on TBHP which chronicles the points very well. Do watch out if there is a loan running and ensure that the seller

closes that and gets the NOC from the bank. In case you are exploring any out of state option, just research the process well.